PassFrame
TUITION

Strange Creatures of a Far-off Island

Year 5 — 11+ Lesson Worksheet (PassFrame Tuition)

Comprehension | Non-fiction (Journal)

Extract — read it carefully before answering

12th March — Our ship anchored this morning off an island so remote that, according to the captain, no chart has ever recorded its exact position. I went ashore with two companions to begin my survey of the local wildlife, and within an hour I had filled an entire notebook with observations.

The most remarkable creature we encountered was a tortoise of truly astonishing size — larger, I should think, than any tortoise described in the scientific journals of home. Its shell, mottled brown and grey, was patterned like the bark of an ancient tree, and it regarded us with a slow, unhurried curiosity, entirely unafraid, as though it had never once encountered a human being in its long life.

Along the black volcanic shoreline, we found lizards unlike any I had studied before: strange, spiny creatures that dived without hesitation into the crashing surf to feed on seaweed, surfacing minutes later entirely unbothered by the cold water. My companion, a keen student of natural history, remarked that he had never heard of a lizard that chose the sea over the land, and I confess I shared his astonishment.

Perhaps strangest of all were the birds. They showed no fear of us whatsoever, allowing us to walk among them and even touch their feathers, as though generations of living without predators had erased all memory of danger from their small minds.

I left the island that evening with a notebook full of wonders and a growing conviction that places cut off from the rest of the world develop in ways no naturalist could easily predict.

Questions

20 min · 12 questions

1. What kind of document is this extract written as?

2. According to the writer, how large was the tortoise compared to those described at home?

3. Underline the sentence that tells you the tortoise was not afraid of the explorers.

4. Underline the simile that describes the tortoise's shell.

5. What does “unhurried” suggest about the tortoise's behaviour?

6. True or false: the lizards on the island avoided the sea.

7. Why do you think the birds “showed no fear of us whatsoever”?

8. What three types of creature does the writer describe in this journal entry?

9. In your own words, explain why the writer finds the birds' behaviour surprising.

10. What does the final sentence suggest about the writer's view of isolated places?

11. Why might the author have chosen to write this extract as a journal entry rather than a report?

12. Do you think this island would still look the same today? Explain your thinking using evidence from the text.